▼ ASSAM

COUNTRY PISTOLS

Jayanta Kumar Das didn't get the BJP's approval for a ticket from Assam's Dispur, so he has turned approver. In an explosive allegation, he says hired young guns are operating 10,000 fake social media accounts out of Room 501 at Atal Bihari Vajpayee Bhawan, the party HQ at Guwahati. That reminded everyone of a February post, on the official BJP handle, of an AI-generated video of CM Himanta Biswa Sarma aiming a gun at a Muslim-looking man standing beside Congress leader Gaurav Gogoi. The caption read: 'Point Blank'. It's now a case in the Gauhati High Court, and the uploader has been offloaded by the party. Yet, in an interview with INDIA TODAY, the CM defended the post, even saying he would repost it from his own handle, with the "correct" caption: "Bangladeshi".■





▼ KERALA

GOOD FOR THE GDP?

Joseph Vazhackan had printed a hundred thousand posters and cutouts starring himself, spending a neat Rs 25 lakh on this burst of vanity publishing. Who could blame him? Everyone in the Congress had assured him, the state vice-prez, that he was a sure shot for the Ettumanoor seat. Yes, right up to those who speak in a Malayali accent in the high command. But when the list came out, the seat had gone to a Kottayam district satrap. New Delhi's veto! His only consolation: Deepthi Mary Varghese from Ernakulam, too, had contributed in vain to India's GDP—by printing her own posters for Kochi. LoP V.D. Satheeshan's veto, this time.

But the most telling stat? The would-be CM apparently got his way only in nine seats. Dominating the battlescape was a distant field marshal, AICC gen-sec K.C. Venugopal, who kept 34 seats for his retinue. Even ex-LoP Ramesh Chennithala bagged 22 seats. So even if the Congress wins the April 9 assembly poll, it would seem KC has written Satheeshan's fate for the five years. ■

▼ TAMIL NADU

Revenge Rerun

These are not eggs you would have put in the same basket. But isolation can guide you imperceptibly to fellow loners. **V.K. Sasikala** and **S. Ramadoss** prove that with an unlikely alliance that has sprung up on the margins of political history. Both were once once central to Dravidian power structures: Sasikala operated at the core of the imperium as the confidante of late AIADMK regina J. Jayalalithaa, till her demise. Ramadoss's writ ran up to New Delhi, but the Pattali Makkal Katchi founder finds himself disinherited by his own son. Anbumani Ramadoss has since steered the party towards the AIADMK–BJP combine. As a salve for this shared experience of loss of glory, the duo are hoping to gather up shards of their old Thevar and Vanniyar vote. So what if it's only fragments? Sometimes, revenge is sweeter than victory.■



ANI

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